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Introduction

Ten years have passed since Salman bin Abdulaziz Al Saud became King of Saudi Arabia on Jan. 23, 2015, and transferred policymaking authority to a younger generation of princes led by his then 29-year-old son, Mohammed bin Salman. Fifteen months later, in April 2016, Prince Mohammed — by then Deputy Crown Prince as well as Minister of Defense — unveiled a comprehensive document called “Vision 2030” as a strategic framework for transforming the Saudi economy and society.¹

More properly viewed as a collection of initiatives rather than a single plan, Vision 2030 is about much more than giga-projects such as Neom — a high density, planned city with a low environmental impact being built by Saudi Arabia in its Tabuk Province.² Although Neom has attracted much of the media analysis devoted to Vision 2030, the overall strategic initiative entails a restructuring of many other aspects of governance and domestic socio-economic priorities.

In its totality, the release of Vision 2030, which was drawn up with the assistance of global consultants, constituted an ambitious statement of intent from a figure seen at the time by many, especially outside the kingdom, as a relatively unknown political novice. Its goals became more urgent when a sharp fall in oil prices in 2015 hit Saudi economic prospects hard. Following a series of budget cuts, Mohammed bin Salman declared that, “2015 was the year of the quick fix, 2016 is the year of the more organized quick fix, and 2017 is the year the vision will begin.”³

Subsequent Vision Realization Programs announced a year after the Vision 2030 launch provided more details about how the government planned to achieve specific aspects of its ambitious plans, including the National Transformation Program, the Quality of Life Program, and the Fiscal Sustainability Program.⁴ A series of giga-projects followed, beginning with Neom in 2017, and soon came to dominate external perceptions of Vision 2030's reforms, even as key domestic initiatives were also unveiled.

Various assessments since have evaluated Saudi Arabia's progress toward the goals outlined by Vision 2030, and several of the giga-projects have recently been scaled back.⁵ This research paper offers context often missing from existing analyses, exploring why some goals have been accomplished more easily than others and how elements of Vision 2030 have evolved since their introduction in 2016. Most analyses have evaluated the kingdom's efforts to reduce its economic dependence on fossil fuel.

However, given Saudi Arabia's influence within the Middle East as well as the global Muslim community, this paper devotes equal attention to Vision 2030's societal

transformation initiatives and builds on the authors' 2019 Baker Institute report, "Mohammed bin Salman and Religious Authority and Reform in Saudi Arabia." Written two years after Mohammed bin Salman became Crown Prince, and at a time when he was shunned by Western policymakers after the killing of Jamal Khashoggi in the Saudi Consulate in Istanbul in 2018, our earlier report assessed the balance between symbolism and substance in Mohammed bin Salman's early reforms, especially in the social sphere.⁶

This new paper — published nearly six years later and more than halfway through the Vision 2030 timeline — takes the narrative forward and focuses on analyzing Saudi progress as 2030 draws near.

Societal Goals

Much of the American media discourse about Crown Prince Mohammed has characterized him as disempowering the Saudi religious establishment, a narrative questioned in the 2019 report.⁷ He has reduced the government's focus on maintaining strict norms of religious observance, including gender segregation and rigid adherence to daily prayer times, which had been enforced by the religious police — a pre-Vision 2030 government committee charged with enforcing Sharia law, i.e., conservative Islamic norms of public behavior. Just 12 days before the formal launch of Vision 2030, the religious police were stripped of certain powers, including arrest, on April 13, 2016.⁸

By promoting gender-integrated spaces, the Crown Prince has encouraged women to participate in public life and significantly altered the lived experience of many ordinary Saudis, men and women alike. He has done so, in part, by modifying the government's definition of Islam.

Redefining Islamic Values

It is noteworthy that the opening bullet point of Vision 2030's first section, "A Vibrant Society," lists "Living by Islamic Values" as defined by "moderation, tolerance, excellence, discipline, equality, and transparency."⁹ While Islamic scripture advocates for these values, they differ significantly from the aspects of Islam that the Saudi government had traditionally prioritized in the past. Essentially, Vision 2030 applies an Islamic veneer to legitimize its societal goals, a time-tested approach for the Saudi monarchy.

One of these goals seeks to reduce male Saudi citizens' reliance on the state for public sector employment, a career path that had become increasingly unsustainable as the overall population grew — especially because these jobs had to be lucrative enough to support all female dependents of the employee's family, since they were barred from working outside the home.¹⁰ Between 2005 and 2015, Saudi labor law permitted women to only hold employment "suitable to their nature."¹¹ Under King Salman, such language

was removed and the Saudi state began to officially support women working outside the home, in part by providing financial incentives to companies that hired women.¹²

By 2023, Saudi Arabia had a female labor force participation rate of 34%, while the U.S. rate was 57% as of early 2025.¹³ The economic burden of strictly adhering to the kingdom's previous religious orthodoxy had become too great, highlighting the interplay between the need for both societal and economic reform. Still, the decision to begin Vision 2030 with a reference to Islamic values demonstrates the Crown Prince's awareness of the need to acknowledge his country's religious heritage, even as he seeks to transform it. While supporting the entry of women into the workforce aligns with the kingdom's economic realities and interests, the leadership has made clear that it is engaged in a top-down distribution of privileges, not a negotiated expansion of rights. The arrest and subsequent detention in 2018 of women advocating for the right to drive illustrated how the authorities feel they can both grant and take away such privileges.¹⁴

A Notable Absence of Backlash

Unlike previous periods of social change in the 1960s and 1970s, conservative elements of Saudi society have yet to mount significant backlash, likely due to the authorities' willingness to impose harsh penalties against internal dissent. An additional factor behind the lack of sustained opposition may be the influence of a generation of Saudis who studied abroad, an experience that left many yearning for Saudi Arabia to become what they consider a more "normal" nation. Under the auspices of the King Abdullah Scholarship Program – which ran from 2005 to 2020, and has since evolved into the Custodian of the Two Holy Mosques Scholarship Program – hundreds of thousands of young Saudis received funding to pursue their education abroad, including many women.¹⁵ The scholarship program illustrates how some of the changes in Saudi Arabia originated during the reign of King Abdullah (2005–15), building on pre-2016 measures.¹⁶

Welcoming Religious Visitors

The first quantifiable goal listed in Vision 2030 is that of welcoming 30 million annual Umrah visitors, or religious pilgrims who come to the holy cities of Mecca and Medina outside of the annual week-long Hajj season. In 2016, the number of annual Umrah visitors totaled 8 million. As of 2024, that had reportedly risen to 16.9 million.¹⁷ Yet given the existing strain on transportation and accommodation infrastructure for pilgrims, researchers have questioned how the Saudi government can realistically accommodate more than 10 million more Umrah visitors each year, especially if it intends to adhere to Vision 2030's pledge to promote environmental sustainability. In addition, climate change-induced high temperatures increase the challenges for visitors, especially when pilgrims come during the summer.¹⁸

Strengthening Saudi Nationalism

While Vision 2030 begins by highlighting Islam, it quickly moves on to a core aspect of Crown Prince Mohammed's agenda: both strengthening and altering Saudi nationalism. The Saudi government has been engaged in various projects to center the ruling Al Saud family and decenter the role of Islam, some of which predated the Crown Prince's rise to power. For example, King Abdullah established Saudi National Day in 2005, which at the time was the only nonreligious annual holiday permitted by the state.¹⁹ Since then, narratives about the history of the Arabian Peninsula, with a focus on pre-Islamic history, have become more widespread and openly accessible. This extends beyond the high-profile development and promotion of sites such as Al-Ula, an ancient oasis city located in the Medina Province — home to a concentration of Arabian historical artifacts — explored in more detail below.

In 2022, King Salman instituted February 22 as Founding Day, the kingdom's second nonreligious annual holiday, to commemorate the establishment of the first Saudi state by then-emir Mohammad ibn Saud in 1727.²⁰ This replaced 1744 as Saudi Arabia's official founding year, a date originally chosen because this was the year Mohammad ibn Saud forged an alliance with the cleric Mohammad Ibn Abdul-Wahhab, the founder of Wahhabism (a fundamentalist branch of Islam based on a literal interpretation of the original Quran). The year 1744 had long symbolized the historical political and religious partnership between the Al Saud dynasty and the descendants of Ibn Abdul-Wahhab, the al-Sheikh family, and the broader Wahhabi religious establishment, which had previously been central to Saudi Arabia's national narrative.

By shifting the foundational year to 1727, King Salman and Crown Prince Mohammed sought to cement the central importance of their family and displace the role of Abdul-Wahhab in the chronology of the nation's birth. The decision to erase the significance of 1744 is as bold as if a U.S. president suddenly proclaimed that the United States would no longer date its founding to 1776.

In 2023, the government inaugurated its third nonreligious holiday, setting March 11 as Flag Day to commemorate the adoption of the Saudi national flag in 1937 by King Abdulaziz Ibn Saud — further reinforcing the role of the Al Saud family in the national story.

The decentering of Islam did not begin with Vision 2030, as demonstrated by scholars such as Rosie Bsheer, who documented efforts to secularize Saudi history following the 1991 Gulf War — when American troops were first stationed inside the kingdom, which drew criticism from Wahhabi clerics.²¹ However, the recent establishment of holidays highlighting the Al Saud family occurred only after time had largely faded public memory of the sometimes contested process of nation-building in the early 20th century.

A Changing Relationship With Tourism

Another facet of how the Saudi state is revising its relationship with Islam is through its view of the territory's pre-Islamic past, specifically the promotion of touristic sites. One of the goals in the first section of Vision 2030 is to "More than double the country's presence on the UNESCO World Heritage List," which it appears on track to accomplish.²² In 2016, Saudi Arabia had four UNESCO World Heritage sites; as of 2024 it had eight, with several more sites submitted for consideration.

In 2008, the first Saudi site UNESCO recognized was Mada'in Salih, or the Al-Hijr Archaeological site, which is part of a larger territory known as Al-Ula.²³ Similar to the archaeological site of Petra in Jordan, Mada'in Salih features elaborate carvings etched into desert stone by the pre-Islamic Nabatean civilization of the first century A.D. Until recently, most Saudis avoided Al-Ula on the basis of a hadith, or saying, of the Prophet Mohammad, which held that his followers should not enter the ancient city because it had been cursed by God.²⁴ Ironically, this belief arguably helped to preserve the Nabatean ruins, as Wahhabi clerics — with the support of the state — historically destroyed many pre-Islamic sites as idolatrous.²⁵

Under the auspices of Vision 2030, the Saudi government elevated Al-Ula as a tourist and cultural destination. For example, Crown Prince Mohammed hosted a GCC Summit at Al-Ula in January 2021 to resolve the Gulf crisis; news coverage featured the leaders in front of the mirrored exterior of the Maraya Concert Hall.²⁶ Maraya subsequently became an iconic background on Instagram after the kingdom paid handsomely for visits by social media influencers.²⁷

Many Saudis and other Muslim tourists have demonstrated their willingness to ignore the hadith by visiting the previously prohibited location for annual events such as the Winter at Tantora Festival and the AlUla Arts Festival. The government has also partnered with globally recognized groups — including the International Union for the Conservation of Nature — to foster the impression that the development of the area is an example of "achieving environmental stability," another of Vision 2030's goals.²⁸ Yet, given the intensive efforts to expand Saudi Arabia's tourism infrastructure, it seems clear that the government hopes to significantly increase visitor numbers, regardless of the impact on local communities and species.²⁹

Saudi Arabia was elected chair of the UNESCO World Heritage Committee for 2023. The focus on UNESCO aligns with a more general effort to celebrate Saudi heritage, including some limited recognition of Saudi cultural diversity.³⁰ Official acknowledgement of the variation of religious and cultural heritage in different parts of the kingdom was long ignored in favor of a homogenized national dress as well as a narrative that prioritized the state's preferred interpretation of Islam — which itself reflected the conservative traditions of the Najd region, the homeland of the Al Saud family. In contrast, since 2019, the Saudi state has celebrated a variety of seasons, such

as Riyadh Season, many of which highlight different regions of the country while also promoting entertainment, including concerts, festivals, and other events.

Promoting Culture and Entertainment

These recent tourism campaigns dovetail with another goal of Vision 2030: “Promoting Culture and Entertainment.” One underlying motivator of this goal was to encourage domestic tourism. For Saudi women, in particular, travel abroad has long offered an opportunity for greater personal freedom than was possible at home. Now, the development of local entertainment and leisure industries aims to attract both locals and foreigners — although many Saudi citizens still seek to escape the oppressive summer heat by vacationing elsewhere. Jeddah Season, for example — named after the kingdom’s second largest city — takes place in the summer, features performances and sporting events, and highlights the tourist attractions along the Red Sea, an area whose development is featured prominently in Vision 2030.³¹

In seeking to transform parts of the country into luxury destinations for foreigners and Saudi citizens alike, the authorities have sacrificed some existing communities. For example, in 2021, the Jeddah Central Project began demolishing large sections of historic Jeddah, despite part of the Old City having been designated as the kingdom’s third UNESCO heritage site in 2014. The destruction of homes and entire communities there provoked rare public dissent at the time, with residents and property owners protesting the lack adequate notice or compensation before their buildings were destroyed.³² Many of those affected were either the descendants of hajj pilgrims, who had remained in the cosmopolitan city, or foreigners attracted by the area’s relative affordability.³³ Like state-led efforts to revitalize historic districts in ancient cities from Cairo to Istanbul, such projects often erase existing communities to make way for sanitized, social-media ready remodels.³⁴

Connecting Societal and Economic Aspects of Vision 2030

Tourism connects the societal and economic aspects of Vision 2030. Together with the hospitality and entertainment sectors, it has emerged as a key feature of Vision 2030’s push to diversify the economy and is central to many of the giga-projects currently being developed. Aside from religious tourism for Muslims performing Hajj or Umrah in Mecca, Saudi Arabia’s leisure travel sector was very limited until tourist visas began to be issued in 2019.³⁵

A February 2020 reorganization of the national cabinet introduced dedicated Ministries of Tourism, Sports, and Investment, but the onset of COVID-19 and lockdowns soon disrupted the development of these initiatives. In October 2021, the Minister of Tourism unveiled a strategy to invest \$1 trillion over ten years with the aim of creating one million new jobs in the sector and attracting 100 million tourist visits a year by 2030. Progress toward these goals has been made, with a global advertising campaign promoting the kingdom inspiring 30 million international travelers in 2024, roughly the

same as France attracted in 2019, immediately before the pandemic.³⁶ However, it emerged that the authorities were using an unconventional definition of the metric “visits.” Instead of counting individual travelers, they specified that “a person who visits 10 destinations in the country during a trip will count for 10 visits.”³⁷ Still, largely positive coverage from prominent outlets like The New York Times, Travel + Leisure, and Condé Nast — even if some of that coverage was sponsored by the Saudi Travel Authority — suggests that the kingdom’s investment has begun to generate returns.³⁸ Time will tell if the \$800 billion investment in the tourism sector will pay off, or if the cultural changes necessary to attract foreigners, such as allowing alcohol, will generate more significant pushback.

Economic Objectives

The economic dimension of Vision 2030 is best viewed as a roadmap for ongoing reform, rather than a static plan with a fixed endpoint. At its core, Vision 2030 charts a path toward a diversified economy, using Saudi Arabia’s resource revenues as a catalyst for change.³⁹

The economic objectives include goals for increasing foreign direct investment from 3.8% to 5.7% of GDP, expanding the private sector’s contribution from 40% to 65% of GDP, raising the share of non-oil exports from 16% to 50% of GDP, growing the percentage of women’s participation in the workforce from 22% to 30%, and developing sectors such as defense localization (i.e., enhancing Saudi Arabia’s ability to fulfill its own military equipment and technology needs instead of relying on imports), mining and critical minerals, renewable energy, and tourism.⁴⁰

Further details on Vision 2030’s economic objectives were provided in the 2016 launch of the National Transformation Program, followed by the development of 11 new vision realization programs in 2017 covering such areas as fiscal sustainability, industrial development, the Public Investment Fund (PIF), and financial and health care sectors.⁴¹

Two key economic goals of Vision 2030 — reducing unemployment from 12% to 7% and raising female workforce participation — are particularly important to young Saudis entering adulthood and the labor market. These policies resonate strongly with the country’s youth and are on track to be achieved. In fact, the female workforce participation goal of 30% was met well ahead of schedule, prompting Minister of Finance Mohammed al-Jadaan in 2024 to raise the target to 40% by 2030, reflecting the rapid progress made.⁴²

The degree to which Vision 2030 and its associated development projects can develop and diversify the economic and industrial base while creating sufficient new jobs for all will be its ultimate test of success. A desire for change after years of stasis is one reason why Vision 2030 was, and remains, popular among many Saudi citizens of the Crown Prince’s millennial generation as well as with younger Saudis.⁴³

Several Vision 2030 priorities seek to build upon the locational and comparative advantages that Saudi Arabia enjoys over other nearby countries, positioning the kingdom as a key player in the emerging chain of geo-economic hubs as the world moves toward the midway mark of the 21st century. This is reflected in the focus placed on the mining sector, as the kingdom seeks to draw on its largely untapped domestic resources of minerals, integrate into evolving global transition supply chains, and invest heavily in processing facilities.⁴⁴

A sense of the scale of ambition and opportunity was provided in 2024 by Khalid Al Madaifer – vice minister for mining and former head of the Saudi Arabian mining company Ma’aden – when he stated that, “We are in the middle of the world. Saudi Arabia is location-wise between three continents.”⁴⁵ Aside from leveraging the kingdom’s geographical connectivity, Ma’aden also partnered with PIF in 2023 to launch the Manara Minerals Investment Company, a joint venture aimed at acquiring external supplies of critical minerals such as lithium, nickel, and copper for domestic processing.⁴⁶

Vision 2030 includes the creation of “national champions” – Saudi companies in key industries supported by the government to become regional and global leaders in their fields. Some progress has been made, albeit with varying levels of success. Saudi Arabian Military Industries (SAMI) was formed in 2017 as a wholly owned subsidiary of PIF, with a mandate to increase the localization of military spending from the figure of 2% of total defense expenditure at the time to a target of 50% by 2030. By 2023, localization had reached 15% and SAMI had developed manufacturing capabilities in advanced electronics and aerospace.⁴⁷

However, churn in senior leadership and challenges in procuring trained staff, especially in the face of stiff competition from the United Arab Emirates, suggest that progress has not been achieved as smoothly as anticipated.⁴⁸ There was also skepticism among some industry veterans as to whether the original plans were realistic. Anthony Cordesman, the late national security analyst at the Center for Strategic and International Studies, labeled the Vision 2030 objective of localizing military spending as “the silliest and least convincing aspect of Vision 2030” with “so few real-world benefits in job creation.”⁴⁹

Key Role of the Public Investment Fund

Virtually every major initiative since Vision 2030 was launched has been connected to the Public Investment Fund. PIF has risen from relative obscurity a decade ago – when it was a locally-focused unit in the Ministry of Finance – to one of the largest and most ambitious sovereign wealth funds worldwide.⁵⁰ In addition to SAMI, PIF has established dozens of companies in sectors from ecotourism and electric vehicles to shipbuilding and space development.⁵¹

One of its most successful endeavors to date has been the Savvy Games Group, which was created as part of the PIF's strategic plan for 2021–25 and built upon a string of prior PIF investments in esports and gaming companies. Savvy is consistent with the PIF's desire to incubate national champions that can transform the kingdom into a central hub of an emerging sector — in this case, the global gaming industry and the booming esports market. In June 2023, the CEO of Savvy told the Financial Times that, "The region is populated with demographics that are favourable to us. When you fold in the national strategy ... and the desire to diversify the economy away from oil and gas, it's a natural assumption to be making a lot of investments in Saudi Arabia toward games."⁵²

Gaming and esports are examples of state-led investments that, in the words of PIF Governor Yasir Al Rumayyan, can contribute to economic diversification by "enabl[ing] the private sector" through partnerships with "innovative, transformative, and disruptive companies around the world" to develop "the industries and opportunities of the future."⁵³ Strategic investments like these aim to establish Saudi leadership in this emerging economy and position the kingdom as a growth engine for market disruptors and technological innovators.

One example is the 2019 acquisition by PIF of a majority stake in Lucid, the electric vehicle manufacturer, followed by the opening in 2023 of a related assembly plant in Saudi Arabia — the company's first such plant outside the U.S.⁵⁴ However, losses incurred by Lucid, and a weakened share price, have necessitated capital injections into the company by PIF. At this point, the impact of Lucid's Saudi venture on local job creation and manufacturing growth is unclear.⁵⁵

High-Profile Projects

Sports are barely mentioned in the text of Vision 2030, but since 2020 Saudi Arabia has emerged as a key player in the changing landscape of global sport — as organizer, investor, and disruptor — and the country has been awarded the right to host the 2034 FIFA Men's World Cup.⁵⁶ The rapidity of the Saudis' move into an array of sports, including soccer, golf, boxing, tennis, and motor racing, signifies a degree of adaptability as Vision 2030 evolves and opportunities arise.⁵⁷ Furthermore, the use of sports is a potent example of how soft power is being used to alter the way the world regards Saudi Arabia, by raising global awareness of a changing kingdom and generating buzz to attract the millions of tourists and new residents who will ultimately populate the country's planned giga-projects.⁵⁸

Vision 2030's adaptability is also evident in the scale of recent Saudi investment in artificial intelligence development, infrastructure, and tech accelerators, with PIF planning to co-invest alongside global partners in a bid to establish the kingdom as a dominant player in the tech sector and build a domestic-focused advanced technology ecosystem.⁵⁹

However, these pragmatic (and much-needed) elements of Vision 2030 coexist alongside the giga-projects announced since 2017, projects that have dominated the kingdom's policy focus, media attention, and funding streams, even as their economic utility remains largely untested. In the eyes of many — particularly those outside the kingdom — giga-projects such as Neom have become synonymous with Vision 2030.⁶⁰ Other signature giga-projects include Qiddiya, a giant entertainment complex outside Riyadh initially slated to open in 2023 but delayed until 2025, several ultra-luxury tourism projects along the kingdom's hitherto-underutilized Red Sea coastline, and ambitious plans for the urban redevelopment of the city centers of Riyadh and Jeddah.⁶¹

Each giga-project has been entrusted to PIF or its subsidiary entities for implementation, illustrating the fund's centrality to both the outcome of Vision 2030 and to Crown Prince Mohammed's ambition. PIF's many domestic mandates mean that it is far from being a conventional sovereign wealth fund with a mandate to invest primarily in external assets.⁶²

Giga-Project Challenges

Multiple difficulties have delayed progress on the kingdom's giga-projects and, at times, have threatened to call into question the viability of economic diversification. Levels of foreign investment in Neom and the other major projects have fallen far short of expectations, requiring capital injections by the government through PIF and its subsidiaries.⁶³ Foreign direct investment plunged in 2017, likely in response to the kingdom's detention of numerous Saudi business elites at the Ritz-Carlton hotel for investigation into potential corruption — just days after the inaugural Future Investment Initiative was held at the same venue and where Neom was announced.⁶⁴ Early suggestions that Neom would be listed on an exchange through an initial public offering have not materialized, and other aspects of the project — such as plans for a transnational dimension that would include Jordan and Egypt, and possibly even Israel — also seem to have been tabled.⁶⁵

Funding Challenges

Although Crown Prince Mohammed stated in a 2016 television interview during the launch of Vision 2030 that, "We need it, but I think in 2020, we can live without oil," he instead needs oil prices to remain high enough to generate the revenues to finance the giga-projects.⁶⁶ This has introduced constraints on Saudi decision-making that even the 2022 windfall of higher oil prices following the full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine could only partly alleviate.

In October 2022 and April 2023, budget pressures were a significant factor in Saudi decisions to push large cuts to OPEC+ production, causing significant friction with U.S. counterparts in the process.⁶⁷ The Wall Street Journal also reported in 2023 that "Saudi

economic advisors have privately warned senior policy makers that the kingdom needs elevated oil prices for the next five years to keep spending billions of dollars on projects that have so far attracted meager investment from abroad.”⁶⁸ As of March 2025, the International Monetary Fund projected that the kingdom needed a breakeven oil price of \$91 per barrel to balance the budget, as the actual price hovered around \$70 per barrel.⁶⁹

Saudi officials responded to shortfalls in oil revenue and foreign investment by tapping local and global debt markets, with multiple bond sales in January and February 2025. They also arranged new credit facilities for PIF and other entities, including in Islamic finance and green bonds.⁷⁰ As reported strong investor demand indicated, these are viable options for Saudi leadership and likely to be increasingly prominent in financing the next phase of Vision 2030. New points of vulnerability may nevertheless emerge, especially when it comes to external or regional volatility. This includes any tightening of monetary policy which could raise the cost of borrowing and any lasting instability in the Red Sea coastal area where many of the giga-projects are located.⁷¹

There are also other financial challenges. While PIF is nearing a target set by Crown Prince Mohammed of managing \$1 trillion in assets by the end of 2025, about half of its growth has been based on asset and capital transfers by the government from other public and state entities like Aramco or the Saudi Basic Industries Corporation (SABIC). The transfer of 8% of Aramco equity accounted for 32% of the growth in PIF’s assets, while the sale of PIF’s 70% stake in SABIC to Aramco added a further \$69 billion to PIF coffers.⁷²

It has also been easier for PIF to make investments internationally than to attract companies to Saudi Arabia. As a result, a key theme of the PIF investor summit held in Miami in February 2025 — attended by business leaders and President Trump — was to highlight investment opportunities inside the kingdom.⁷³

Rising costs at Neom and elsewhere, as well as potential bottlenecks in construction materials, are additional obstacles to delivering the project-based aspects of Vision 2030. Records obtained by The Wall Street Journal suggest that the first phase of Neom would cost \$370 billion through 2035 and that the total cost through 2080 — the project’s target completion date — would be \$8.8 trillion.⁷⁴ Sindalah, a luxury resort on an island in the Red Sea —and one of the first phases of Neom to formally open — was reportedly three times over budget and three years late. Even then, according to Eliot Brown and Rory Jones, “Hotels were unfinished, high winds disrupted ferries and golf, and much of the site was still under construction” when the resort opened in October 2024.⁷⁵ Trojena, a planned mountain destination and ski resort slated to host the Asian Winter Games in 2029, saw its projected costs double in two years, again according to documents reviewed by The Wall Street Journal.⁷⁶

Concerns about the apparently unsustainable levels of spending and impractical scale of projects such as The Line — a high-tech linear megacity within Neom — have been allayed by signs over the past year that several of the giga-projects would be downsized

and opened in phases rather than all at once. Whereas The Line was originally planned to extend over 170 kilometers (approximately 106 miles), reports in 2024 suggested that only 2.4 kilometers (1.5 miles) would be completed by 2030 — a timeline that may now be pushed to 2034.⁷⁷ Interim plans to construct 16 kilometers (10 miles) of The Line would, according to one report, have “meant constructing the equivalent of all the office buildings in Midtown Manhattan three times over in a decade” and “require significant portions of the world’s available steel and window glass.”⁷⁸

In April 2024, Minister of Finance Mohammed Al Jadaan acknowledged that while 87% of the 1,064 initiatives launched as part of Vision 2030 were on track, “there are challenges obviously,” adding, “We will change, we will adjust [or] extend some of the projects” if necessary.⁷⁹ A separate target to double Riyadh’s population to 15 million by 2030 also appeared to be under review, with a more realistic aim of reaching 10 million residents by the end of the decade under consideration.⁸⁰

Reality Versus Hype

While Saudi Arabia’s successful bid to host the 2034 Men’s FIFA World Cup may have sparked accusations of “sports-washing” in European and North American media, the decade-long run-up to the 2034 event provides a buffer against the expectations placed on 2030 as the defining date for measuring the success of Vision 2030.⁸¹ While Saudi officials have long maintained that it is a roadmap rather than a rigidly defined endpoint, the hype given to its giga-projects risked generating unrealistic expectations if the reality fell short. The new 2034 targets extends the timeline beyond 2030, easing pressure on the original deadline and giving authorities four additional years to operationalize and open key initiatives in a sequential manner, rather than all at once. In addition, the scaling back of projects such as The Line indicates that pragmatism is guiding the economic decisions around Vision 2030 — suggesting a more realistic approach to its giga-projects as they advance toward construction and delivery.

Echoes of Pre-Vision 2030 Ambitions

Vision 2030 is not the first long-range strategic plan drawn up by the Saudi authorities. In 2005, as oil prices began a boom that lasted until 2014, officials unveiled a long-term strategic plan to cover development through to 2024.⁸² One of the centerpieces of the plan involved the creation of six large economic cities by 2020, but only the King Abdullah Economic City (KAEC) saw any significant progress as the projects struggled to generate buy-in from stakeholders across the kingdom’s bureaucratic apparatus and various agencies involved.⁸³ With an initial target of two million residents, by 2024 KAEC had only attracted 10,000. Despite this shortfall, the adjacent King Abdullah Port has become a critical node in Saudi Arabia’s infrastructure since it opened in 2019. Reflecting on the city’s struggles, a former government advisor told the Financial Times in 2018 that, “If KAEC was viable the city would have taken off a long time ago. The marketing was amazing but the whole concept behind it was flawed. The economic base was never there.”⁸⁴

The travails of KAEC and other pre-2016 initiatives such as the King Abdullah Financial District (KAFD) were noted in the original 2016 Vision 2030 document, which acknowledged that work had started at KAFD “without consideration of its economic feasibility.”⁸⁵ However, a key difference between the pre-2016 projects and the Vision 2030-related initiatives is that the latter have the backing of the leadership at the highest level in the form of the Crown Prince and PIF, which was not always forthcoming in previous eras of development. This was evident at a 2017 briefing in Washington, D.C., when David Ottaway — a journalist who has covered the region for decades — observed how the governor of PIF, Yasir al-Rumayyan, “dismissed any parallel, noting that KAEC had depended totally on private investors, whereas the PIF he headed stood behind Neom.”⁸⁶

Conclusion

While 2030 may have seemed distant in 2016, Saudi Arabia’s selection to host the 2034 FIFA Men’s World Cup has given authorities four additional years to advance key Vision 2030 projects. A downsizing of several of the giga-projects also suggests a newfound sense of pragmatism about what is feasible and achievable, both in terms of logistical and financial resources. Many of the less-heralded domestic components of Vision 2030 cumulatively amount to a process of social and economic change that look set to continue as the first decade of Vision 2030 draws closer.

The speed and scale of new announcements has spurred accusations of multiple types of “washing” from international critics, including art-washing, green-washing, and sports-washing.⁸⁷ In 2023, Crown Prince Mohammed told Fox News that “if sports washing [is] going to increase my GDP by way of 1%, then I will continue to do sports washing. I don’t care.”⁸⁸ The heavy investment into global sports has enabled Saudi authorities to reach a mass audience worldwide, raise awareness of the changes underway, and generate an undeniable buzz aimed at the millions of new residents and visitors needed to populate all the projects as they open.⁸⁹

Going forward, the level of resources poured into the initiatives and projects that collectively make up Vision 2030 mean that progress will be closely monitored, internally and externally, as these plans move toward the implementation and delivery, or reassessment, phase. Cost overruns and supply bottlenecks, as well as regional and geopolitical disruption, will require careful management — particularly given the Red Sea is increasingly associated with renewed conflict and uncertainty. These challenges also indicate that external deadlines and escalating costs could turn the 2029 Asian Winter Games into a marker of the Saudi authorities’ ability to translate vision into reality as 2030 fast approaches.

Notes

¹ Vision 2030 is a comprehensive document and strategic framework for achieving Saudi Arabia's long-term goals as a kingdom. It details plans to diversify its economy, primarily to reduce its dependence on oil; develop a more knowledge-based society that includes an enhanced quality of life and improved public services; and create a more transparent and accountable government (Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, "Vision 2030 Overview," accessed June 25, 2025, <https://www.vision2030.gov.sa/en/overview>).

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